

A record output of 227 million tonne of foodgrain helps the agriculture minister stem the criticism against him and vindicates his vision for Indian agriculture

■ By Shankkar Aiyar

At around 11 a.m., Agriculture Minister Sharad Pawar eagerly awaits an SMS. No, the message is not about the Indian Premier League. It is from his officials who send him the scores on a day-to-day basis on harvesting and procurement of foodgrain. Last week, as his slim mobile phone silently whirled, he checked the message and smiled to himself. His department had set a new record by procuring 210 lakh tonne—108 lakh tonne more than the previous year—for 2007-08, triggering worries of storage capacities for the future. For the first time in the history of Independent India, foodgrain production has crossed 227 million tonne, causing global rice futures to dip 26 per cent and wheat prices to come down from \$360 to \$250 a tonne. What's more, in each of the principal categories, output has notched an all-time record (see chart).

Much maligned as "the minister for BCCI and the minister for IPL" by the Opposition, the Left and allies within the ruling combine for over three years, this is Pawar's moment of triumph, vindicating his diagnosis of and prescription for agriculture. "I had said this in 2004 and I am repeating it now. Since 1996, Indian agriculture had been starved of investment and credit to farmers. When we came, viability and thus self-sufficiency was under threat." To get a perspective of the pressure on agriculture, consider this: In 1947, agriculture supported 80 per cent of the 350-million populace, or 280 million people. Today it is supporting over 620 million, with 82 per cent farmers holding less than 2 hectare of land, of which 60 per cent are dependent on rain. Small wonder, the share of agriculture in GDP has shrunk from 61 per cent in 1951 to 19 per cent now. It means that more people are now dependent on a smaller slice of the pie.

AGRICULTURE

PAWAR'S POWER CROP



HARVEST SEASON:
Sharad Pawar